THE MENTAL HEALTH FIRST AID CONNECT USER GUIDE

For Adult and Youth MHFA Learners

Mental Health FIRST AID
from NATIONAL COUNCIL FOR MENTAL WELLBEING

Updated: April 2025

ABOUT THE NATIONAL COUNCIL FOR MENTAL WELLBEING

Founded in 1969, the National Council for Mental Wellbeing is a membership organization that drives policy and social change on behalf of nearly 3,500 mental health and substance use treatment organizations and the more than 10 million children, adults and families they serve. We champion policies that support access to high-quality services. We build the capacity of mental health and substance use treatment organizations. And we promote greater understanding of mental wellbeing as a core component of comprehensive health and health care. Through our Mental Health First Aid (MHFA) program, we have trained more than 2.5 million people in the U.S. to identify, understand and respond to signs and symptoms of mental health and substance use challenges.

ABOUT MENTAL HEALTH FIRST AID

Mental Health First Aid, a program from the National Council for Mental Wellbeing, teaches the public how to identify, understand and respond to signs and symptoms of mental health and substance use challenges. The program has four primary courses:

Mental Health First Aid is a skills-based training that teaches people how to identify, understand and respond to signs and symptoms of a mental health or substance use challenge in adults ages 18 and over. The evidence behind the program demonstrates that it builds mental health literacy, providing an action plan that teaches people to safely and responsibly identify and address a potential mental health or substance use challenge. Mental Health First Aid, sometimes called Adult Mental Health First Aid, is available in English and Spanish.

Youth Mental Health First Aid is a skills-based training that teaches parents, family members, caregivers, teachers, school staff, peers, neighbors, health and human services workers and any other citizen how to identify, understand and respond to an adolescent (ages 12-18) who may be experiencing a mental health or substance use challenge. Youth Mental Health First Aid is available in English and Spanish.

teen Mental Health First Aid is a skills-based training that teaches teens in grades 10-12, or ages 15-18, how to identify, understand and respond to signs and symptoms of a mental health or substance use challenge among their friends and peers. The program equips young people with the knowledge and skills they need to take care of their own mental health and to support each other, including how to get the help of a trusted adult.

Mental Health First Aid at Work is a skills-based training program that teaches participants how to identify, understand and respond to someone who is experiencing a mental health or substance use challenge in a work environment and connect them with appropriate employee resources if necessary. The program can benefit businesses of all sizes and in all sectors by empowering employees with mental health awareness tools and skills.

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MHFA CONNECT GLOSSARY

Adult MHFA Supplement courses – Supplements to the Adult Mental Health First Aid (MHFA) course that include additional content tailored to a specific population or market (e.g., Higher Ed, First Responder). (Formerly called "modules.")

Blended courses – Used broadly to describe MHFA courses that include both self-paced and Instructor-led content.

- **Blended – *with in-person Instructor-led training*** – One of the two Blended options for Adult and Youth MHFA. After completing a 2-hour, self-paced online course, learners will participate in a 4.5-hour to 5.5-hour Instructor-led training in person. tMHFA has six sessions. Within every session teens take a self-paced course and an Instructor-led session that can be conducted in-person.
- **Blended – *with virtual Instructor-led training*** – One of the two Blended options for Adult and Youth MHFA. After completing a 2-hour, self-paced online course, learners will participate in a 4.5-hour to 5.5-hour, Instructor-led training via videoconference. Due to the nature of virtual learning, the virtual Instructor-led training may take longer than the In-person Instructor-led training. tMHFA has six sessions. Within every session teens take a self-paced course and an Instructor-led session that can be conducted virtually.

1st Edition – 8-hour In-person Adult and Youth courses last updated in 2016.

2nd Edition – In-person and Blended Adult and Youth MHFA courses last updated in 2022.

- Seven learning segments comprise the 2nd Edition Youth MHFA In-person course. The course may be taught in a single 6.5-hour segment or divided into two sessions and delivered over two days.
- The 2nd Edition Adult In-person course consists of 10 learning segments. The course may be taught in a single 7.5-hour session or broken into two sessions and delivered over two days. (See Blended course for information on timing.)

Blended pre-work – Self-paced course module(s) that must be completed prior to taking the Instructor-led training for Blended Adult, Youth or Instructor training courses.

certified – Holding an Instructor credential to teach a program or successfully completing a program as a First Aider. If an Instructor holds more than one credential, they are "multi-certified." If an Instructor fails to maintain their credential, they are "decertified."

Coordinator – A person who manages courses and participants on behalf of a group of Instructors.

Course Assistant (also "Virtual Hallway Monitor") – An Instructor, a non-participating mental health clinician or a non-participating certified Mental Health First Aider who does not need to participate in the training, but must be on call in case a participant needs to use the Virtual Hallway. This role is only necessary if an Instructor and co-Instructor are teaching between 20 and 30 learners during a virtual Instructor-led training.

course preparation – Self-paced activities a learner must complete prior to the Instructor-led training. Includes an opinions quiz and pre-evaluation. Not to be mistaken with Blended pre-work, the self-paced work learners in Blended courses must complete prior to Instructor-led training.

credential – A signifier that an Instructor is certified to teach a specific MHFA program.

end-of-course work – Self-paced activities a learner must complete after Instructor-led training to earn their First Aider certificate. Includes final exam and post-evaluation.

final exam – A graded exam taken by Mental Health First Aid learners to measure their application of MHFA skills at the end of a course.

First Aider – A person who successfully completes a Mental Health First Aid training.

First Aider training – A course that trains new First Aiders (e.g., teen First Aider training, Adult First Aider training).

follow-up evaluation – Survey taken by MHFA learners to measure information retention and use of MHFA skills after course is complete.

In-person course – Face-to-face Instructor-led training with no self-paced e-learning required. Content hours vary with the curriculum and the edition of the curriculum.

Instructor – A person leading a Mental Health First Aid training. In courses with more than one Instructor, "Instructor 1" is the primary instructor, and "Instructor 2" is the second Instructor (co-Instructor) who helps teach and manage the training.

Instructor applicant – Person who has begun an application but has not yet been accepted into an Instructor Training course.

Instructor candidate – Person enrolled in Instructor Training.

Instructor training – Course that trains new Instructors.

Instructor-led training or Instructor-led session – The section of a course that is led by an Instructor. This can be in person or via a videoconferencing platform. The in-person course is an Instructor-led training. Note: Sometimes called ILT on the MHFA Connect platform.

learner – A person in a Mental Health First Aid training

Learning Badge – Icons visible to Instructors on their Connect homepage that signify the curricula and supplements they are certified to teach.

A
ASSESS
for risk of suicide or harm.

L
LISTEN
non-judgmentally.

G
GIVE
reassurance and information.

E
ENCOURAGE
appropriate professional help.

E
ENCOURAGE
self-help and other support strategies.

Mental Health First Aid Action Plan (ALGEE) – A tool for providing Mental Health First Aid:

Mental Health First Aid Connect, MHFA Connect, Connect – The learning management system that hosts all MHFA courses. It is also a platform Instructors, Coordinators and National Trainers use to find resources and connect via forums.

module – The components of a course in MHFA Connect, such as an evaluation, a self-paced course or an Instructor-led session.

opinions quiz – Survey taken before the Instructor-led training to measure a Mental Health First Aid learner's opinions, attitudes and beliefs about mental health.

pre-evaluation – Survey to measure a learner's knowledge prior to taking a Mental Health First Aid course.

post-evaluation – Survey to measure a learner's knowledge following a Mental Health First Aid course and to gather their feedback on their Instructor-led training experience.

pre-work – Any course module(s) that must be completed prior to taking the Instructor-led training for Blended Adult, Youth or Instructor training courses.

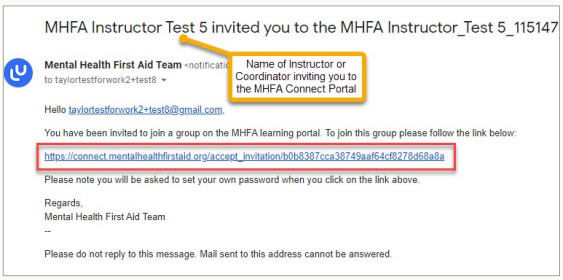
program – One of the four main MHFA courses (i.e., Adult MHFA, Youth MHFA, teen MHFA, MHFA at Work). Within MHFA Connect, a program is called a course.

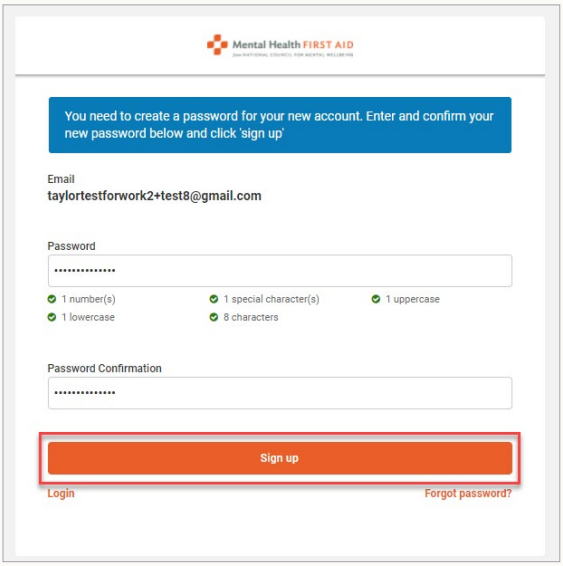
roster – List of learners enrolled in a course.

FOR ASSISTING LEARNERS:

1. HOW A LEARNER SETS UP THEIR MHFA CONNECT ACCOUNT

The first act in a learner will undertake in MHFA Connect will be setting up their MHFA Connect account.





1. Accept the MHFA Connect Invite and click the link to be directed to the MHFA Connect sign-up page.

   Once a learner registers for your Mental Health First Aid (MHFA) course, the Instructor or Coordinator will follow one of the two processes for creating learner accounts. If the Instructor or coordinator invites them to MHFA Connect, rather than creating the account for the learner themselves, they will receive an email that looks like this:

2. Create a password for their account by entering a Password and Password Confirmation. Then click Sign Up. Passwords must have at least eight characters and include the following: one number, one uppercase letter, one lowercase letter, one special character.

3. Complete their user profile. Required fields are in red text:

   a. First Name
   b. Last Name
   c. What brings you to MHFA Connect?
   d. Work Address Line 1
   e. Work Address Line 2
   f. Work Address City
   g. Work Address State
   h. Work Address ZIP Code
   i. Phone Number
   j. Are you part of a member organization?
   k. Organization
   l. Job Title
   m. Would you like to receive news and updates from MHFA USA and the National Council for Mental Wellbeing?
   n. Instructor Public Profile
   o. Instructor Dietary Restrictions
   p. Instructor Dietary Restrictions – If Allergies/Other Preferences, please describe

What brings you to MHFA Connect? *

What brings you to MHFA Connect?

This field is required

Work Address Line 1 *

Work Address Line 1

This field is required

Work Address Line 2

Work Address Line 2

Work Address City *

Work Address City

This field is required

Work Address State *

Work Address State

This field is required

Work Address Zip Code *

Work Address Zip Code

This field is required

Phone Number

Phone Number

Do you teach MHFA in or for one of the following groups? (Select N/A if you do not teach MHFA in or for any of the groups.) *

Do you teach MHFA in or for one of the following groups? (Select N/A if you

This field is required

Are you part of a member organization? *

Are you part of a member organization?

This field is required

Organization

Organization

Job Title

Job Title

Would you like to receive news and updates from MHFA and the National Council for Mental Wellbeing? *

Would you like to receive news and updates from MHFA and the National C

This field is required

Instructor Public Profile

Instructor Public Profile

Instructor Certification Status

N/A

Instructor Accredited Date

N/A

Instructor Anniversary Date

N/A

Instructor Dietary Restrictions

Instructor Dietary Restrictions

Instructor Dietary Restrictions - If Allergies/Other Preferences, please describe

Instructor Dietary Restrictions - If Allergies/Other Preferences, please descrit

4. Once they select **Save**, they will be redirected to their account dashboard.

   Remind the learner there will not be a course on their MHFA Connect dashboard after they save their learner profile. The invitation simply gives them the opportunity to create their learner profile in MHFA Connect. It is important to emphasize to your learners completing this account creation process allows an Instructor to enroll them in a future course. Once a learner is enrolled in a course, they will see it on their account dashboard.

2. HOW A LEARNER, INSTRUCTOR OR COORDINATOR CAN VIEW MHFA CONNECT IN SPANISH

Did you know that you can change the language of MHFA Connect to Spanish? From your MHFA Connect Dashboard, select the circle with your initials (located in the top right corner of the screen). Select “Language: US English” from the menu that appears, and then select “Spanish.”

3. HOW DO LEARNERS PREPARE FOR A COURSE?

Learners must complete the pre-evaluation, opinions quiz and Blended pre-work (if applicable) before they can attend the **Instructor-led training.** These assignments account for 69% of the course content and are an important part of a future First Aider's course experience. Learners in a Blended course complete pre-work that includes the following:

- Welcome to Mental Health First Aid.
- First Aider Course Instructions.
- Mental Health First Aid Pre-evaluation.
- Mental Health First Aid Opinions Quiz (not applicable for tMHFA).
- Mental Health First Aid Self-paced Course.

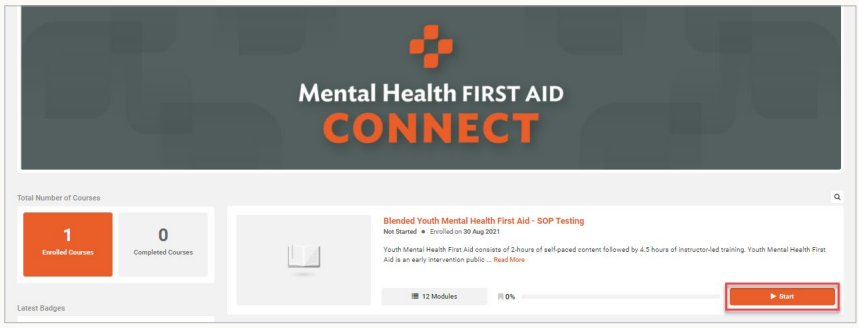
Before the course, blended Adult and Youth learners are also granted access to the following resources. We strongly encourage learners to review them before the Instructor-led training. (Reviewing them prior to the session is encouraged, but not required.)

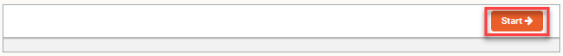
- Mental Health First Aid Participant Manual (Youth or Adult)
- Self-care Plan Template
- Exit Ticket
- Mental Health First Aid Participant Processing Guide (Youth or Adult)

A learner can scroll through the course content after selecting the Start button in the left-hand widget. They must complete each assignment before moving on to the next -- they cannot complete assignments out of order. Learners do not have to complete the Blended pre-work in one sitting; they can step away from their pre-work at any time. When a learner wants to continue their pre-work, they login to their MHFA Connect account at https://connect.MentalHealthFirstAid.org/ and select the **Resume** button.

4. HOW A LEARNER COMPLETES THEIR PRE-EVALUATION, OPINIONS QUIZ AND BLENDED PRE-WORK

1. Log in to MHFA Connect at https://connect.MentalHealthFirstAid.org/. The learner will be on their homepage, **My Courses.**
2. Click the **Start** button under the enrolled course to begin with a review of the course description and learning objectives.

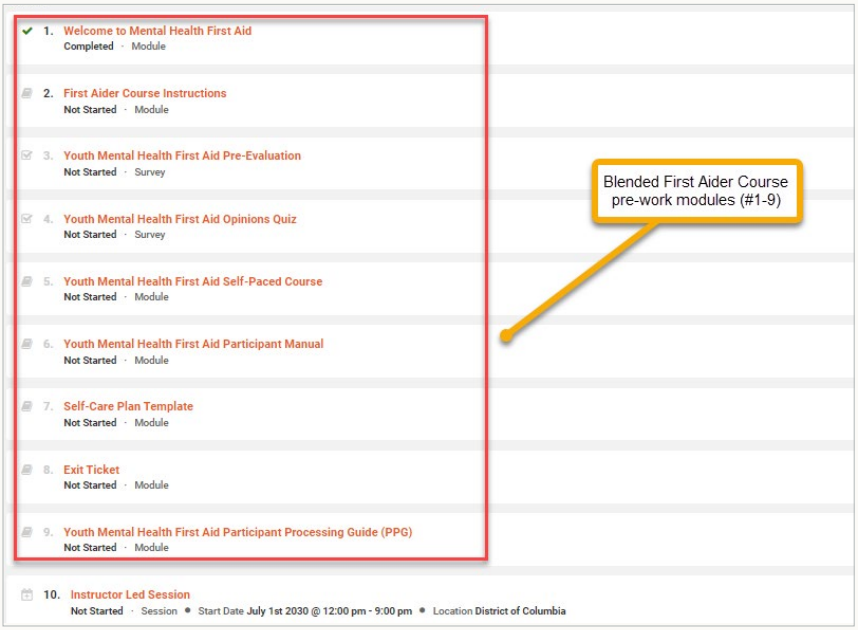




After you complete each Blended pre-work module, select **Next Module** in the top right corner. You cannot advance to the next module until you have completed the current module.

Note: Learners must complete all Blended pre-work modules prior to the Instructor Led Session! The Instructor will unenroll or transfer any learner who does not completed these assignments before the session.

3. Then, select **Start** in the top right corner of the Course Description page to continue to the first module, **Welcome to Mental Health First Aid.**



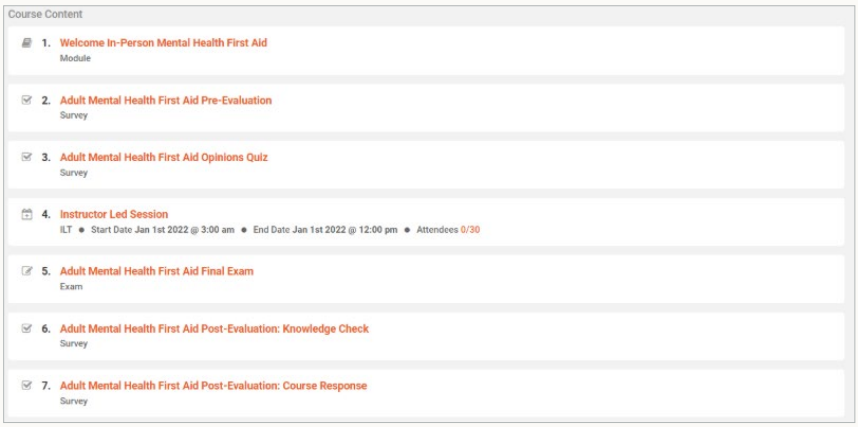


*Image depicts the course content for a 2nd Edition Youth Course. Your experience may vary depending on the course.

Blended Course Pre-work Modules:

- Welcome to Mental Health First Aid
- First Aider Course Instructions
- Pre-evaluation
- Opinions Quiz
- Mental Health First Aid – Self-Paced Course
- MHFA Participant Manual (resource)
- Self-care Plan template (resource)
- Exit Ticket (resource)
- MHFA Participant Processing Guide (resource)

In-person Course Preparation Modules:

- Welcome and Instructions
- Pre-Evaluation (2nd Edition only)
- Opinions Quiz.

5. HOW A LEARNER REVIEWS ENROLLED AND COMPLETED COURSES

Learners can review the courses they are currently enrolled in or have completed. A PDF version of their course history is available to them for printing or sharing.

1. Log in to MHFA Connect at https://connect.MentalHealthFirstAid.org/ to get to the homepage, **My Courses.**

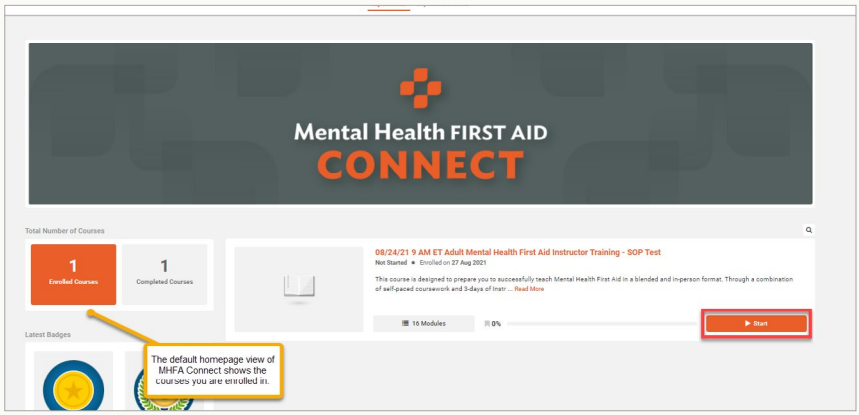
   a. **To view Enrolled Courses:** In the left-hand widget, there's a button that says **Enrolled Courses.** These are the courses they are currently registered in that have a status of **Not Started** or **In Progress.** The learner may start or resume any of these courses.

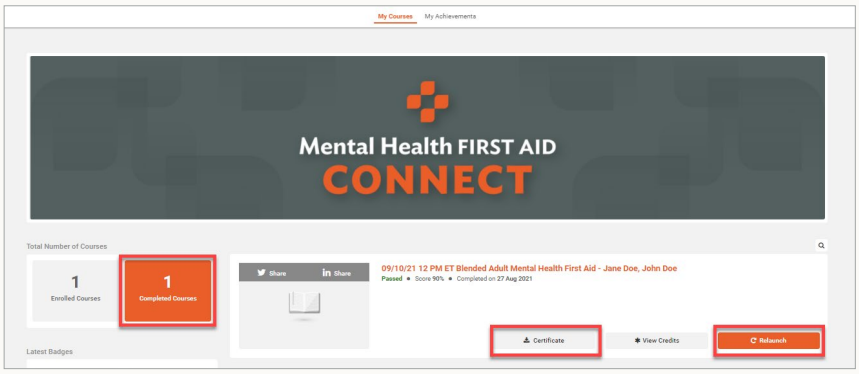
   b. To view **Completed Courses:** In the left-hand widget, select **Completed Courses**.

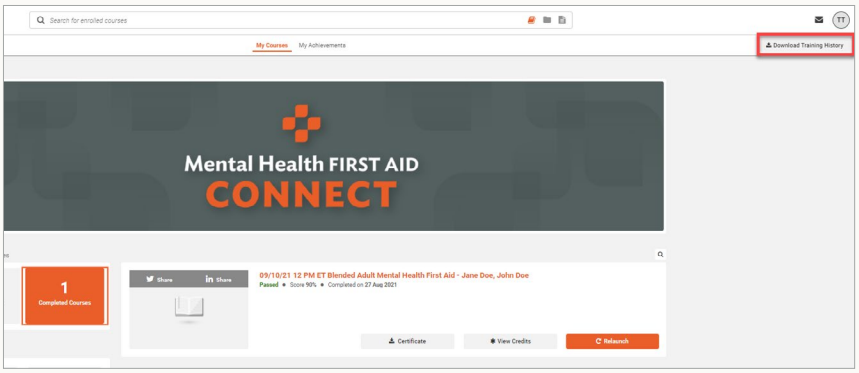
      i. Select **Relaunch** to review course content at any time.

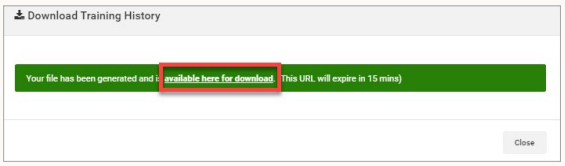
      ii. Select **Certificate**, then select the **Available for Download** link, to open the certificate in a PDF file they can be saved and/or printed.

   c. After completing at least one course, the learner will be able to select **Download Training History** in the top right corner of the Completed Courses page.







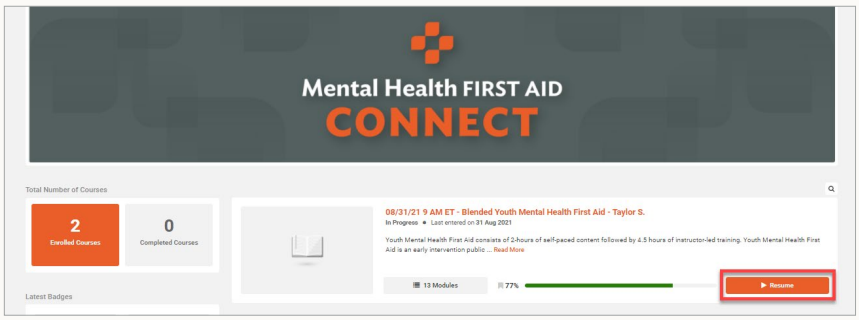


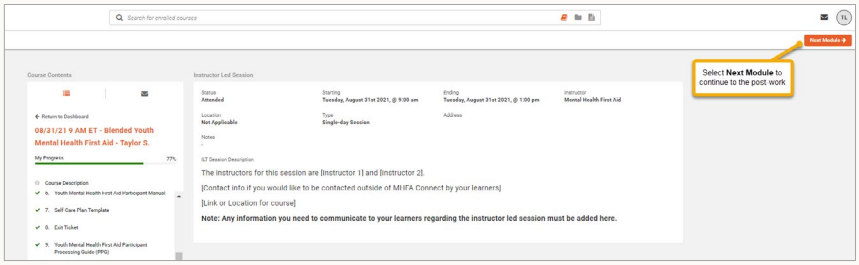
Click **Available Here for Download** to open the complete course history, including certificates/credits, as a PDF document that can be saved or printed.

6. HOW A LEARNER COMPLETES THE COURSE AND ACCESSES THEIR CERTIFICATE FOLLOWING THE INSTRUCTOR-LED SESSION

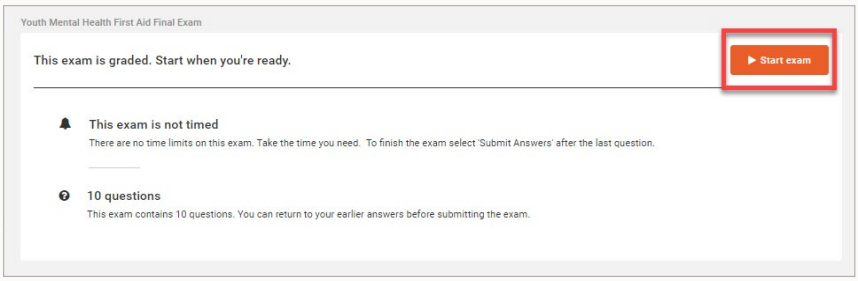
To finish their training and become Mental Health First Aiders, learners must complete the final exam and post-evaluation.

For Adult and Youth MHFA Courses





1. Log in to MHFA Connect https://connect.mentalhealthfirstaid.org/.
2. From the homepage (the **My Courses** page), select **Resume** on the enrolled course.
3. On the left side of the page, there's a menu of course contents. Scroll to the Instructor Led Session module. If the Instructor or Coordinator has marked the learner in attendance for the Instructor-led session, there will be a green checkmark next to Instructor Led Session, and the status will say attended. The learner selects Next Module to move to the final exam and post-evaluation. **Note:** If a learner's status shows as **Not Started,** they cannot move forward with the final exam and post-evaluation.



4. Assignment 1: Final Exam
   a. The first assignment after the Instructor-led session will be the Final Exam. Select **Start Exam.**

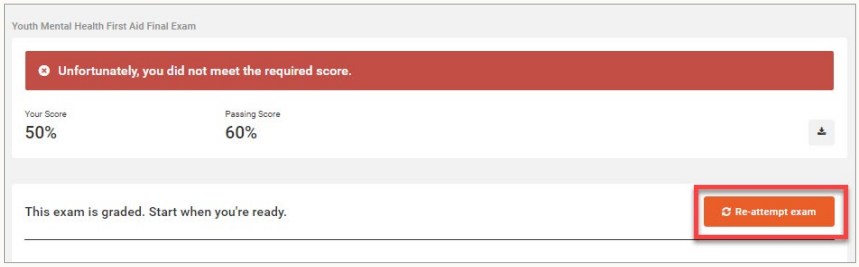
      This is a 10-question, graded exam, and learners must get a passing score of at least 60% to continue. With each question, the learner selects their answer then selects **Next Question.** Upon answering the last question, select **Submit Answers.** In the pop-up message, select **Submit Answers** again or select **Cancel** to return to the exam.

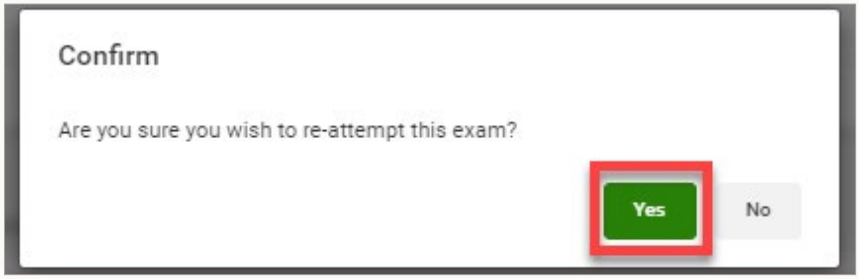
   b. Once the learner submits answers to the exam, they will see their score and their responses.
      i. If the learner scores 60% or higher, they select **Next Module.**
      ii. If the learner does not score 60% or higher, they can select **Re-attempt Exam,** then click **Yes** to confirm they want to re-attempt the exam. With each question, the learner selects their answer then selects **Next Question.** Upon answering the last question, the learner will select **Submit Answers.** In the pop-up message, select **Submit Answers** again or select **Cancel** to go back to the exam.

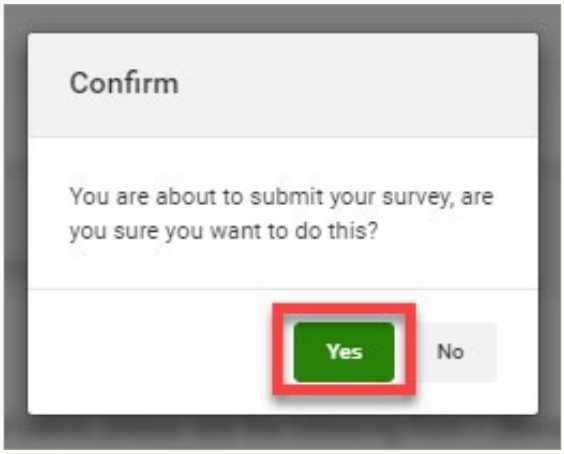
5. Assignment 2: Post-evaluation(s)

The second assignment is the post-evaluation. Once the learner answers each question, they will select **Next Question.** Upon answering the last evaluation question, the learner will select **Submit Survey.** Select **Yes** to confirm submission or **No** to go back to the survey.

Note: Blended courses require learners to submit two post-evaluations before completing the course and accessing their certificate.







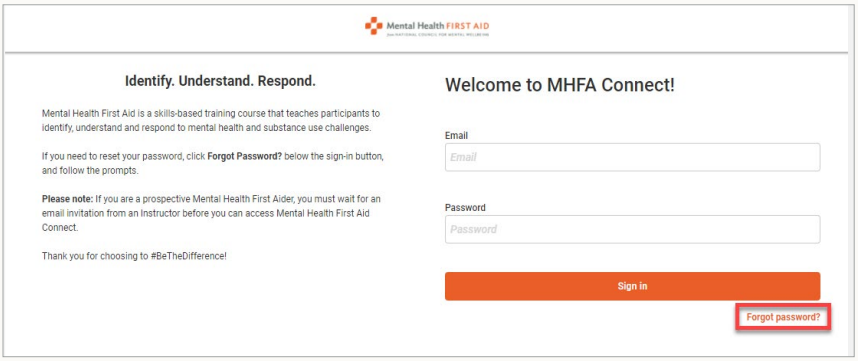
6. Download the Certificate

   a. Once the learner submits the post-evaluation surveys, they have completed the course. They are a First Aider! To access the certificate from this screen, select **Download.** Then select **Available Here for Download** from the **Download Certificate** window. This will open the certificate as a PDF they can save or print.

   b. The learner may choose to access their certificate at a later time. They'll log in to their account, and select **Completed Courses** in the left-hand widget. Then, they select **Certificate** and **Available Here for Download** from the **Download Certificate** window. This will open their certificate as a PDF they can save and/or print.

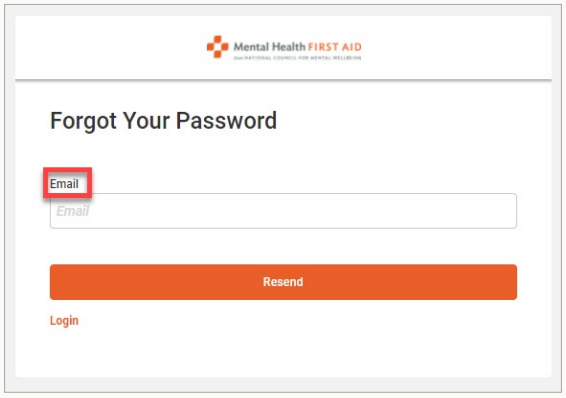
7. HOW TO RESET A PASSWORD

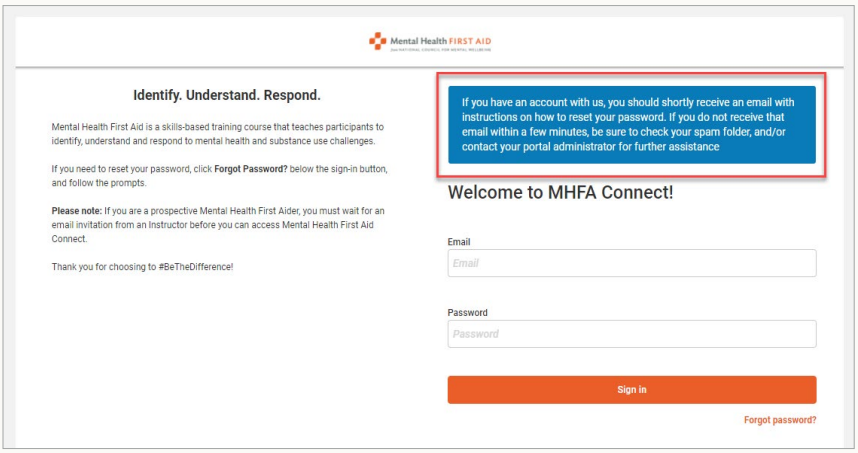
Everyone forgets their password sometimes. If this happens to you, don't worry, just follow these steps to reset it. If you are unable to use the **Forgot Password** feature, please reach out to your Instructor.



1. Navigate to https://connect.MentalHealthFirstAid.org.
2. Select **Forgot Password** under the **Sign In** button.

3. This will bring up a **Forgot Your Password** window. Enter the email address you use for MHFA Connect under **Email** then select **Resend.**

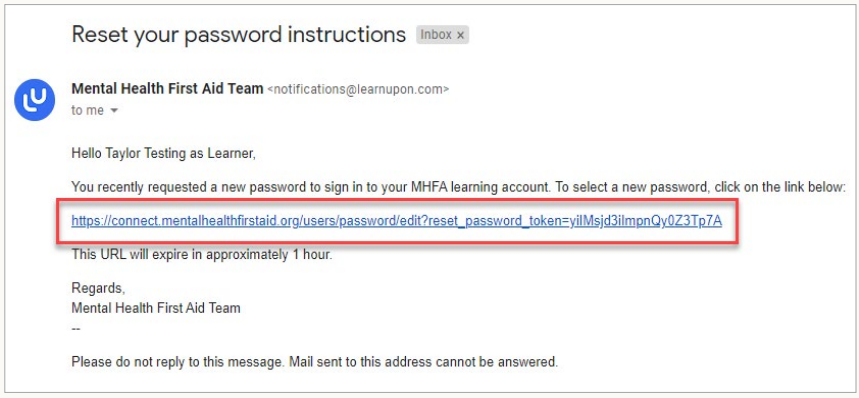


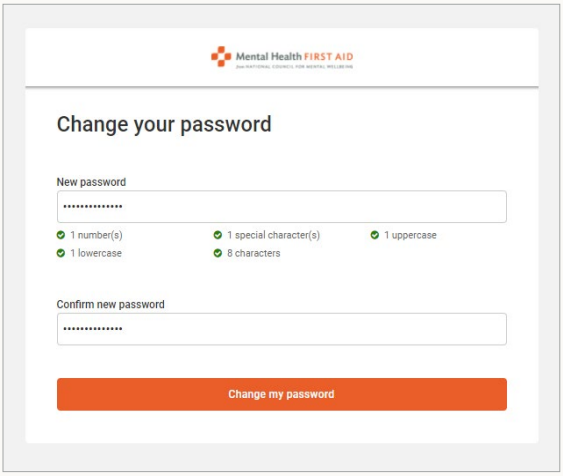


4. You will be redirected to the MHFA Connect login page with a next-steps message: *"If you have an account with us, you should shortly receive an email with instructions on how to reset your password. If you do not receive that email within a few minutes, be sure to check your spam folder, and/or contact your portal administrator for further assistance."*

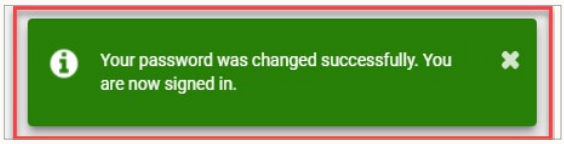
   Note: It may take a few minutes to receive the password reset email. Please be patient.

5. Check your email for a message from the Mental Health First Aid Team with the subject line **Reset Your Password Instructions.** Open the email and click the link in it to select a new password.





6. Selecting the link will bring you to the MHFA Connect **Change Your Password** page. Enter your **new password** and **confirm new password.** Then select **Change my password.**

Note: This will update the password to your account and log you into your MHFA Connect account. You will use your new password the next time you log in to your MHFA Connect account.

7. Once logged into your account, you will see a green window in the lower right corner of your screen that says, **Your Password was Changed Successfully. You are Now Signed In.**